

RESEARCH INDEPENDENCE POLICY

Rationale

The University of Mindanao thru its Research and Publication Center recognizes the vital role of research in the generation of new knowledge for the improvement of the quality of human life. This Research Independence Policy ensures to uphold and promote a culture of intellectual independence and freedom in inquiry, provide precise rules that guarantee independent and responsible research methods, and protect researchers from undue interferences. This policy covers the scope, guiding principles, rights and responsibilities of the researchers to pursue their scholarly activities with independence and impartiality.

Scope

The policy applies to all teaching and non-teaching personnel involved in research activities, graduate and undergraduate students, visiting scholars and research fellows affiliated with the University of Mindanao.

Guiding Principles

Academic Freedom and Autonomy. Researchers have the right to choose their own research topics, methodology, collaborators, and dissemination platforms as long as their choices are in line with the University's research agenda and core values, policies, standards, and ethical norms.

Intellectual Integrity. Researchers are expected to carry out their job with honesty, responsibility, and transparency adhering to the research standards and ethics policy of the institution and the other relevant national and international standards.

Transparency and Accountability. Researchers are expected to declare to the UM administration through the Head of RPC any possible conflicts of interests and maintain open records of their study procedures, funding sources, and other pertinent information.

Rights and Responsibilities.

Researchers. Researchers have the right to exercise research independence responsibly without interference from outside forces including the right to choose their topic, methodologies, and collaborators based on academic merit and relevance. They are expected to uphold academic integrity and professional standards including the conduct of data collection, analysis, and reporting. Moreover, they are anticipated to seek ethical clearance in all aspects of their research; thus, any related academic misconduct shall be dealt in accordance with the operational procedures and policies of the institution. Also, they are encouraged to seek external funding to support their research endeavors, provided that such funding does not compromise the independence or objectivity of the research process, and that transparency and accountability are upheld regarding funding sources and potential influences on research outcomes. When in doubt, they should consult and/or see advice from the RPC on particular concerns pertaining to research independence.

Research and Publication Center. RPC, as the competent research arm of the University, shall keep an eye on adherence and mediate conflicts pertaining to research independence. It is expected to uphold and defend researchers' independence in line with the accepted norms and legal safeguards. Also, RPC is expected to provide researchers with the necessary resources, training, and support – including access to libraries, laboratories, funding opportunities, and regular workshops on research methodologies, ethics, and best practices – to uphold academic freedom, integrity, and impartiality in their scholarly activities. Research management and operations of the University is guided by its research manual and operational procedures manuals.

Compliance

All individual conducting research within the University are required to abide by this policy. Any violation may lead to the proper disciplinary measures, which may include written warnings, the suspension of research privileges, or in, extreme situations upon due process, the termination of employment or academic standing in the University (*See Employees' Manual*). The Research and Publication Center accepts confidential reports of non-compliance or concerns via valid written complaint and can be channeled through email or in-person consultation.

Implementation and Review

The Research and Publication Center shall be responsible for the supervision of the implementation of this policy in collaboration with the relevant authorities across the institution. This policy shall be reviewed annually to make sure it remains applicable, appropriate, efficient, and relevant with the objectives of the institution and with the changing research standards and practices. Feedback from the academics, researchers, students, and external collaborators/partners will be actively solicited. The review process will be headed by the Head of the Research and Publication Center. Changes of this policy shall be recommended to the Management for consideration and approval. All authorized modifications shall be formally communicated to interested parties and shall take effect as soon as approved.

Signed:

(Sgd) GUILLERMO P. TORRES, JR.
University President